billion (Rs 21.6 lakh crore). Similarly, when I became PM in 2014, the size of India's economy was $2 trillion (Rs 167 lakh crore) and at the end of 2023-24, India's GDP will be more than $3.75 trillion (Rs 312 lakh crore). It is this track record of 23 years which shows this is a realistic target.

Q. The Opposition says inflation and lack of jobs is hurting the poor. What would you say to these critics?
Let's put allegations aside and discuss the facts. Despite two years of a once-in-a-century pandemic and global conflicts disrupting global value chains and even causing recessionary pressures across the world, India has shown remarkable resilience. Despite heavy odds, global crises, supply chain breakdowns and geopolitical tensions impacting global prices of basic items, average inflation from 2014-15 to 2023-24 (till November) was only 5.1 per cent, compared to 8.2 per cent during the previous 10 years (2004-'14). Which is higher, inflation of 5.1 per cent or 8.2 per cent?

Q. What about creation of jobs?
As for creation of jobs, it has been the topmost priority of my government. All our efforts have been geared to this task. It is well-known that investments in infrastructure have a large multiplier impact on growth and employment. Hence, we have constantly increased capital investment outlay. The budget of 2023-24 has increased it steeply to Rs 10 lakh crore, up from Rs 1.9 lakh crore in 2013-14. I believe you should enlighten your readers on how this expenditure is productive and creates so many opportunities for the common man. Also, look at what is happening around us. Infrastructure creation is happening at a never-seen-before pace, and all sectors are doing much better than how they were 10 years ago.

Q. What is the outcome of the infrastructure creation that you talked about in terms of employment?
When India took the length of metro lines to 905 km from 248 km in less than 10 years, would it not have created more jobs? When India took the number of airports to 149 from 74 in less than 10 years, would it not have created more jobs? When the number of medical colleges increased from 387 to 706 in less than 10 years, would it not have created more jobs? Compared to the situation before 2014, if the construction of roads has doubled, would it not have created more jobs? If the number of tourists is increasing, would it not be creating more jobs? If agriculture production has risen significantly after 2014, has it not created more livelihood opportunities? This is why, in recent years, labour markets have witnessed falling unemployment rates, down from 5.8 per cent in 2018-19 to 3.2 per cent in 2022-23. This has been accompanied by a rising labour force participation rate, increasing from 50.2 per cent in 2018-19 to 57.9 per cent in 2022-23. The EPFO had 277.4 million members as of March 31, 2022, compared to the 117.8 million on March 31, 2014.



"Parivarvadi parties find the democratic churn in the BJP difficult. Ours is a cadre-based party, driven by a clear mission. We all began as grassroots workers, came up the ranks through hard work"

Q. The BJP has selected fresh faces for the three states it won recently, a trend that you have set since you became PM. What is the thought process behind this?
This is not a new trend. In fact, I am the best example of this practice within the BJP. When I became the CM of Gujarat, I had no prior administrative experience and was not even elected to the legislative assembly. Yes, it may appear like a fresh trend, because most of the other parties today are *parivarvadi* (dynasty-based) parties.

Q. How is the BJP different from these so-called *parivarvadi* parties?
Parivarvadi parties find this democratic churn difficult. The BJP has the ability to nurture multiple generations of leadership at the same time. Look at the presidents of the BJP and you will see fresh faces every few years. Ours is a cadre-based party, driven by a clear mission. We all began as grassroots workers and rose through the ranks on the back of dedication and hard work. This commitment is why the nation, especially the youth, feels a strong connection with the BJP. In